Monday Nite Footballers Commentary

By Jim Nunnelly

Editors Note: The comments in this column were rendered by the sports-minded wives of the Monday Night Footballers. While each wanted to remain anonymous, the reason for including them in this particular column is obvious.

Debi Thomas: Falling or Rising?...

DEBI THOMAS

Did Debi Thomas fall or did she rise? That is a big question and as always, history will judge her. Before we answer that question, let's look back to that Saturday night, when a Super-Bowl-like audience watched Debi in the Calgary Winter Olympics. The tension. The disappointment. The dignity.

Everybody knew that Debi Thomas was tense. Some even say that she just plain "froze up." Especially since she was the leading competitor and was to perform last. Many believe this was the cause of her eventual defeat. The athletic anticipation turned into neurotic waiting and finally emotional exhaustion. After all, the eyes of the entire world awaited her arrival, particularly after the cautious performance of her ever-present rival, Katarina Witt.

That night at Calgary, history was made with an ebony "soul on ice." Debi took to the paradise-like pavement, knowing that she had to beat not only Witt, but a Japanese youngster and a homegrown Canadian. All had performed above and beyond expectations.

Now quickly to the disappointment. Within a minute from her beginning, an unsteady turn flawed her hopefully-perfect long program. And after the second flaw, we all knew that her hopes for the top medal had fallen and faded. And as they showed the Thursday night before, the restrictively strict judges would reduce her score from gold to bronze. The disappointment was there. And we all felt it.

Yes, the much-publicized ice goddess had fallen. And no, the "Star Spangled Banner" would not play for Debi. And at last, the realization of having lost began to slowly set into her face. Debi, her gender, her country, third world nations, Monday Nite Football wives, and a whole race of hopeful blacks shared the disappointing fact-that the possibility of a black Olympic figure skating champion would have to be delayed to another point. Another time. Dignified and astonished, she searched for a way out. She searched for the right words to describe the long awaited, fought-for dream that had slowly slipped away. Not in Calgary. Not in 1988. Not in the Olympics.

Commentary

A way out. Oh, no. She didn't really need a way out. Debi Thomas has won not only a bronze medal, but gained the hearts and respect of all-the-world athletes and spectators alike.

Regaining her stately, slightly-girlish smile, one could see her accepting the victorious defeat and mentally preparing herself for the next challenge. Not an athletic challenge, but an academic one.

After the now-famous, whisper-like, "I'm sorry," Debi mentally slipped from the ice, back to studying medicine at Stanford. She neither explained nor complained. And unlike so many athletes, she was prepared for the day when her athletic prowess, physical grace, and the hand clapping crowd would not be a part of her everyday world. In her head, she hung up the figure skating shoes and reached for the long, white, physician only coat. Though we didn't actually see this transition occur, we knew that she was about to become another star, this time in the classroom.

We salute you Debi for your many achievements in your short twenty year lifespan. Those on and off the ice. Most of all, we congratulate you for rising, every time you fell.

Reproduced with permission of the copyright owner. Further reproduction prohibited without permission.